stupid’—which meant that for many voters it became a case of ‘anyone but Congress’. P. Chidambaram, former finance minister, put it aptly when he told me post-election, ‘The economy destroyed us in the 2014 elections. Had we got growth back on track and inflation under control, everything else might have been forgotten.’

And yet, no election is determined overnight by a single issue or even by one towering individual. This book is, therefore, about much more than just Modi and Rahul. Like a multi-starrer, it contains many characters who played a role in the eventual shaping of the verdict. I have tried to locate some of them in the wider context of the constantly evolving Indian political landscape.

Elections are not a one-day match. While the final act may have been played out on 16 May when the results were announced, the build-up began much before, in fact quite a few years before D-Day. And it is by tracing those roots that we can make sense of the present. I do firmly believe, for example, that the Congress-led UPA lost the 2014 elections in 2011 itself, the year corruption caused a volcanic eruption in public anger. After that, the party and the government were like a comatose patient on slow drip—the end was preordained. Similarly, the rise of Modi wasn’t instant magic—it was the outcome of a deliberate, well-crafted campaign that evolved over several years. Indeed, my central premise is that when the UPA’s decline began four years ago, Modi had already begun planning for his daring Delhi bid. It was a long, single-minded journey to the top, not an overnight coup.

This book, I must warn you, isn’t written by a political scientist or a psephologist. I belong to the more humble tribe of news reporters—every time I look in the mirror, I see a sleeves-rolled-up reporter first, only then a preachy editor or jacket-and-tie anchor. As pen-pushers or sound-bite warriors, we perhaps lack the conceptual base of academics or the number-crunching skills of pollsters. But what journalism does provide is the best seat in the house—you can meet, observe, understand all kinds of people you report on. Your sources share stories and anecdotes that years later can actually be spun into a long narrative. This book is built on the edifice which twenty-six years of journalism have so kindly provided—the chance